GeneScript: A Biology-Inspired Programming Language

Compiler Construction Project

https://github.com/AhsanNaveed121/GeneScript

Course	Compiler Construction (BCS-7G)
Instructor	Sir Faisal Aslam
Phase 1	Interpreter (Flex and Bison)
Phase 2	Ahead-of-time compiler (LLVM IR, compiled with Clang)

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1. Project Overview and Language Purpose

GeneScript is a small, beginner-friendly language for bioinformatics students. In most languages DNA and RNA are plain text, so a typo such as "ATXG", or RNA used where DNA belongs, runs without complaint and only shows up later as a wrong result. GeneScript makes dna and rna built-in types and checks them before the program runs, with error messages that state the biological rule that was broken.

Key ideas from the proposal:

- **Built-in DNA and RNA types.** DNA may contain only A, C, G, T; RNA only A, C, G, U. Any other letter, or a mix of the two alphabets, is a compile-time error.
- **Biology keywords.** A function is a gene, express returns a value, report prints, blocks end with stop, and the program starts at gene nucleus().
- **Value-first syntax.** "ATGC" -> dna g declares a variable; tail(g) -> g assigns.
- **Built-in operations.** head(s), tail(s), s@i, #s, fuse a b, ~d (reverse complement) and transcribe(d).
- **Biological data only.** Every value that is stored, passed, returned or printed is a DNA or RNA sequence. Integers exist only as loop bounds, positions (s@i), #s and loop counters.

Concept	GeneScript
Function / return	gene name(dna a, rna b) ... stop, express e
Entry point	gene nucleus() (exactly one, no parameters)
Declaration / assignment	e -> dna x, e -> rna x, e -> x
Output	report e

If / else if / else	when c ... otherwise when c ... otherwise ... stop
Loops	cycle i across s, cycle i from a to b, grow until c
Break / continue	halt / skip
Logic	both, either, lacks, values bound / unbound
Comparisons	= (whole sequences), < > <= >= (single bases only)
Literals	"ATGC", "" (empty), 'G' (one base)
Comment	^^ until the end of the line

2. Phase 1: Interpreter Architecture

source.gene -> Lexer (Flex) -> Parser (Bison) -> AST -> Semantic analysis -> Interpreter
src/lexer.l src/parser.y src/semantics.cpp src/interpreter.cpp

1. **Lexical analysis** (src/lexer.l). Turns the source into tokens: keywords, operators, sequence and base literals, integers, identifiers and ^^ comments. An unknown character is reported as file:line: unrecognized character and stops compilation.
2. **Parsing** (src/parser.y). A Bison grammar for value-first declarations, prefix fuse, the when / otherwise when chain (one stop per chain), the loops and gene definitions. It builds the abstract syntax tree defined in include/ast.h.
3. **Semantic analysis** (src/semantics.cpp), in three passes:
   - collect every gene's signature and reject duplicate gene names, so a gene can call any gene in the file, before or after it;
   - infer each gene's return type from all of its express statements (including ones nested in conditions and loops), repeating until nothing changes, so recursion and mutual recursion are typed correctly;
   - check every gene body: literal alphabets, DNA/RNA type rules, argument types, the integer rules (#s only as a loop bound, s@i positions, cycle bounds), conditions, halt / skip placement, and exactly one nucleus().

   Scopes are handled by include/symbol_table.h. All errors are collected and printed in the form file:line: message followed by an explanatory note line.
4. **Interpretation** (src/interpreter.cpp). A tree-walking interpreter evaluates the AST directly in memory: there is no intermediate bytecode. Execution starts at nucleus().

3. Phase 2: LLVM Ahead-of-Time Compiler Architecture

source.gene -> same front end as Phase 1 -> CodeGenerator -> program.ll -> clang -> native executable
(lexer, parser, semantics) src/codegen.cpp + runtime/gs_runtime.c

- **Shared front end.** The compiler uses exactly the same lexer, parser and semantic analyzer as the interpreter, so both report identical errors, and no IR is written for an invalid program.

- **Code generation** (src/codegen.cpp). Walks the checked AST and writes textual LLVM IR (a .ll file). IRContext handles functions, basic blocks, unique labels, temporaries and scopes; CodeGenerator lowers each GeneScript construct.
- **Value representation.** Every DNA/RNA value is a pointer (ptr) to an immutable, reference-counted GsSeq { refcount, len, kind, data }. Literals are constant globals. Conditions are i1 values and integers are i64.
- **Genes.** Each gene becomes define ptr @gs_gene_<name>(ptr ...). A generated C main calls @gs_gene_nucleus. Calls to genes defined later in the file need no declarations, so recursion and mutual recursion work directly.
- **Control flow** uses LLVM basic blocks and br i1 branches: when.then.N, when.else.N, when.end.N for conditions; cond / body / step / end blocks for loops; halt and skip branch to the loop's end and step blocks; both / either short-circuit through a phi.
- **Runtime** (runtime/gs_runtime.c). A small C library for the sequence operations, report, and reference counting. genec -c compiles it together with the IR.
- **Driver** (src/genec.cpp). The genec command runs the interpreter, writes IR, or calls Clang to build an executable.

The full ABI (value layout, calling convention, ownership rules) is in docs/LLVM_BACKEND.md.

4. Dependencies and Installation (Ubuntu / Linux)

Package	Needed for
build-essential (g++, make)	building everything
flex, bison	generating the lexer and parser
clang	genec -c ahead-of-time compiler and compiler tests
llvm	llvm-as, used by compiler tests to verify IR (optional)
python3-reportlab	generating README.pdf from markdown (make pdf)

sudo apt update sudo apt install -y build-essential flex bison clang llvm
python3-reportlab
(Alternatively, if using Python virtual environments: pip install reportlab)

The project was verified on Ubuntu 24.04 and 26.04 LTS with g++ 13/15, flex 2.6.4, GNU Bison 3.8.2, GNU Make
4.4.1 and Clang 18/21.

On Windows, use WSL (Ubuntu) and run every command inside the Ubuntu terminal. The programs built by make are Linux executables and cannot run from Git Bash or PowerShell.

5. Building the Project

Run these from the project root:

Command	Result
make	builds everything: bin/genescript, bin/genec (copied to ./genec) and bin/genescript-llvm
make interpreter	builds only the Phase 1 interpreter bin/genescript (no Clang needed)
make compiler	builds only the Phase 2 tools bin/genec, ./genec and bin/genescript-llvm
make clean	removes bin/, ./genec, the generated lexer/parser and all .o files

Building needs only g++, flex and bison. Clang is needed when compiling GeneScript programs to native code (genec -c) and for make test-compiler.

6. Running Programs with the Interpreter

./genec tests/sample1_filter.gene

Without options, genec runs the program with the Phase 1 interpreter. bin/genescript tests/sample1_filter.gene is the standalone Phase 1 interpreter and behaves identically. The exit status is 0 on success and 1 after a compile-time or runtime error.

```
$ ./genec
Usage: ./genec <source.gene>                run with the interpreter
       ./genec -S <source.gene> [-o out.ll]  write LLVM IR
       ./genec -c <source.gene> [-o prog]    compile to a native executable
```

7. Generating LLVM IR and Native Executables

Command	Result
./genec -S prog.gene	writes LLVM IR to prog.ll in the current directory
./genec -S prog.gene -o out.ll	writes LLVM IR to out.ll
./genec -c prog.gene	builds the native executable ./prog
./genec -c prog.gene -o name	builds the native executable ./name

For example:

```
./genec -c tests/sample2_mergesort.gene -o mergesort
./mergesort
```

genec -c writes the IR to a temporary file and runs clang -O2 <tmp>.ll runtime/gs_runtime.c -o <name>. It finds runtime/gs_runtime.c next to the genec executable (or one folder above it, for bin/genec). Two environment variables change this: CLANG selects the compiler (default clang) and GS_RUNTIME gives the path of gs_runtime.c. If Clang is missing or fails, genec prints a message, exits with status 1 and leaves no executable.

IR written with -S can also be compiled by hand:

```
./genec -S tests/sample1_filter.gene
```

```
clang sample1_filter.ll runtime/gs_runtime.c -o sample1_filter ./sample1_filter
```

An excerpt of the IR for a small gene, showing a condition as basic blocks and a br i1:

```
gene first(dna s)               ; GeneScript source     when s =
""          express s     stop
    express head(s) stop

define ptr @gs_gene_first(ptr %p.s) { entry:
%v.s.0 = alloca ptr, align 8   %t1 = call ptr
@gs_seq_retain(ptr %p.s)   store ptr %t1, ptr
%v.s.0, align 8   %t2 = load ptr, ptr %v.s.0,
align 8
  %t3 = call i32 @gs_seq_equal(ptr %t2, ptr @.seq.0)
%t4 = icmp ne i32 %t3, 0   br i1 %t4, label %when.then.1,
label %when.end.0 when.then.1:   %t5 = load ptr, ptr
%v.s.0, align 8
  %t6 = call ptr @gs_seq_retain(ptr %t5)
%t7 = load ptr, ptr %v.s.0, align 8   call void
@gs_seq_release(ptr %t7)   ret ptr %t6
when.end.0:   %t8 = load ptr, ptr %v.s.0,
align 8
  %t9 = call ptr @gs_seq_head(ptr %t8)
%t10 = load ptr, ptr %v.s.0, align 8   call
void @gs_seq_release(ptr %t10)   ret ptr
%t9 }
```

8. Example Programs and Expected Output

Both proposal samples give the same output with the interpreter and as native executables.

*Sample 1: filter G and C bases (*tests/sample1_filter.gene*)*

```
gene gc_filter(dna seq)   ^^ keeps only the G and C bases of a DNA sequence     "" ->
dna result     cycle i across seq          when seq@i = 'G' either seq@i = 'C'             fuse
result seq@i -> result          stop     stop     express result stop

gene nucleus()
"ATGGCCATTGTA" -> dna g
report gc_filter(g)     report ~g

    transcribe(g) -> rna r
report r stop

$ ./genec tests/sample1_filter.gene                    # Phase 1: Interpreter
$ ./genec -c tests/sample1_filter.gene -o sample1       # Phase 2: AOT Compiler $
./sample1                                  # Run native executable
GGCCG
TACAATGGCCAT
AUGGCCAUUGUA
```

*Sample 2: recursive merge sort (*tests/sample2_mergesort.gene*)*

```
gene merge(dna a, dna b)   ^^ joins two sorted sequences into one     when
a = ""          express b     stop     when b = ""          express a     stop     when
head(a) < head(b)
```

```
        express fuse head(a) merge(tail(a), b)
otherwise         express fuse head(b) merge(a,
tail(b))     stop stop
gene split_even(dna s)   ^^ bases at positions 0, 2, 4, ...
    when s = ""         express s     stop     express
fuse head(s) split_odd(tail(s)) stop

gene split_odd(dna s)   ^^ bases at positions 1, 3, 5, ...
    when s = ""         express s
stop     express split_even(tail(s))
stop

gene merge_sort(dna s)   ^^ sorts the bases of a DNA sequence      when tail(s)
= ""         express s     stop     express merge(merge_sort(split_even(s)),
merge_sort(split_odd(s))) stop

gene nucleus()
"GATTACA" -> dna g
report merge_sort(g) stop

$ ./genec tests/sample2_mergesort.gene                # Phase 1: Interpreter
$ ./genec -c tests/sample2_mergesort.gene -o mergesort  # Phase 2: AOT Compiler $
./mergesort                                  # Run native executable
AAACGTT
```

More examples, one per language feature, are in tests/compiler/ (for example recursion.gene, mutual_recursion.gene, loops.gene, break_continue.gene), each with its expected output in tests/compiler/expected/.

9. Error Examples

Every compile-time error is printed as file:line: message plus a note line, all errors are listed, and compilation stops with exit status 1. No IR or executable is produced.

*Lexical error (*tests/compiler/errors/lexical_error.gene*)*

```
gene nucleus()
"ACGT" -> dna g $
report g stop
```

```
tests/compiler/errors/lexical_error.gene:3: unrecognized character '$'.          GeneScript has no such
symbol; sequences go in quotes and comments start with ^^. Compilation stopped: 1 error.
```

*Syntax error (*tests/compiler/errors/syntax_error.gene*): a* when *without its* stop

```
gene nucleus()
"ACGT" -> dna g
when g = "ACGT"
report g stop
```

```
Syntax Error at line 7, col 5: syntax error near " Compilation stopped:
1 error.
```

Semantic errors

The proposal's sample (tests/error.gene, the single line "ATXG" -> dna x):

```
tests/error.gene:1: invalid base 'X' in DNA literal.
DNA allows only A, C, G, T. Compilation stopped: 1
error.
```

Mixing DNA and RNA (tests/llvm/errors/fuse_dna_rna.gene, line 5 is report fuse d r):

```
tests/llvm/errors/fuse_dna_rna.gene:5: cannot fuse dna with rna.              fuse requires
both sequences to have the same biological type.
Compilation stopped: 1 error.
```

Wrong argument types (tests/compiler/errors/call_arg_type.gene):

```
tests/compiler/errors/call_arg_type.gene:8: argument 1 of gene 'only_dna' must be dna, but got rna.
DNA and RNA are separate types; a parameter accepts only its declared type.
tests/compiler/errors/call_arg_type.gene:9: invalid base 'U' in DNA literal.              base 'U' is RNA only; DNA
allows only A, C, G, T. Compilation stopped: 2 errors.
```

Other semantic errors covered by tests include: undeclared variables, redeclaration, #s outside a loop bound, invalid s@i positions and cycle bounds, ordering operators on whole sequences, ~ or transcribe on RNA, conditions that are not conditions, assigning to a loop counter, halt / skip outside a loop, wrong argument counts, undefined or duplicate genes, return-type mismatches, a missing or duplicated nucleus(), and statements outside any gene.

Runtime error

Ordering operators need single bases. When a variable holds more than one base, the check happens at run time; output printed before the error is kept and the exit status is 1:

```
$ ./genec tests/compiler/runtime_errors/ordering_in_gene.gene
A Runtime Error (line 3): ordering operators compare single bases only, but got "AC" and "G".
```

10. Source Files and Folders

Path	Description
src/lexer.l	Flex scanner: keywords, operators, literals, ^^ comments, lexical errors
src/parser.y	Bison LALR(1) grammar; builds the AST
include/ast.h	AST node classes, the runtime Value type, and evaluate / execute hooks
include/symbol_table.h	Nested scopes and symbols (variables, read-only loop counters)
include/semantics.h, src/semantics.cpp	Semantic analyzer: signatures, return-type inference, type and biology rules, error messages
include/interpreter.h, src/interpreter.cpp	Phase 1 tree-walking interpreter
src/main.cpp	Driver for bin/genescript (Phase 1 interpreter only)
include/codegen.h, src/codegen.cpp	Phase 2 code generator: AST to textual LLVM IR
src/genec.cpp	Driver for genec: interpreter, -S (IR) and -c (native via Clang)

src/llvm_main.cpp	Development driver bin/genescript-llvm (IR only), used by tests/llvm
runtime/gs_runtime.h, runtime/gs_runtime.c	C runtime linked into every native program
docs/LLVM_BACKEND.md	Phase 2 design: runtime ABI, calling convention, ownership, control flow
Makefile	Build and test targets (sections 5 and 11)
generate_pdf.py	Builds README.pdf from README.md (make pdf, requires reportlab)
CMDS.txt	Quick terminal reference cheat-sheet for Phase 1 & Phase 2 commands
tests/*.gene, tests/expected/	Phase 1 tests: the proposal samples, error.gene, and regression tests fix*.gene
tests/run_tests.sh	Phase 1 regression test runner
tests/llvm/	Phase 2 backend tests (valid programs, errors/, expected/), runtime_unit.c, runner
tests/compiler/	End-to-end genec tests: features, runtime_errors/, errors/, expected/, runner
docs/GeneScript_Proposal.pdf	The original language proposal
bin/ (generated)	Built programs and test output; removed by make clean

11. Automated Tests

```
make test          # Phase 1: interpreter tests (needs only the interpreter) make
test-compiler   # Phase 2: backend tests + end-to-end genec tests (needs clang)
make test-llvm      # only the backend tests (tests/llvm)
```

- make test runs the two proposal samples and error.gene, then tests/run_tests.sh, which compares the output of each tests/fix*.gene program with tests/expected/.
- make test-compiler runs two suites:
  - tests/llvm/run_llvm_tests.sh: a unit test of the C runtime; every tests/llvm/*.gene program is turned into IR, verified with llvm-as, compiled with clang -Werror, run, and compared with its expected output and with the interpreter; every tests/llvm/errors/*.gene program must be rejected with the expected diagnostics; and every Phase 1 program in tests/ must give the same result natively.
  - tests/compiler/run_compiler_tests.sh: for each feature program, the interpreter and the native executable must both exit with status 0 and both print the expected output; runtime-error programs must exit with status 1 in both; every invalid program must be rejected by genec -c and genec -S with exit status 1 and no executable or .ll file; every other test program in the project must give the same output and exit status natively as in the interpreter; and the genec options and failure cases (missing file, unknown option, Clang missing or failing) are checked.

Native test programs are also built with AddressSanitizer and must run with no memory errors or leaks. Set GS_NO_ASAN=1 to skip those runs, or CLANG=clang-18 (for example) to choose the Clang version. Test output is written under bin/.

Results of a clean build on Ubuntu 26.04.1 LTS (make clean && make && make test && make test-compiler):

Suite	Result
make test	14 passed, 0 failed (plus the two samples and error.gene, which print the outputs shown in sections 8 and 9)
make test-compiler: backend suite	55 passed, 0 failed, 0 skipped (1 runtime unit test, 20 valid programs, 17 error programs, 17 Phase 1 programs)
make test-compiler: end-to-end suite	102 passed, 0 failed (11 feature programs, 1 runtime error, 13 invalid programs, 54 regression programs, 23 CLI checks)

12. Known Limitations

- **Syntax error messages** come from Bison and use the form Syntax Error at line L, col C: ... near 'token', without the file name. At the end of the file the token is empty (near '') and the line is one past the last line.
- **Block scoping differs for reused names.** The interpreter keeps one set of variables per gene call, so declaring a variable (or a loop counter) inside a block with the same name as an outer one overwrites the outer one. The compiled program uses block scope, as the proposal describes for counters. The two give different output only for such programs; no test program reuses a name this way.
- report **of a condition** (for example report g = "A") is accepted and prints an empty line in both the interpreter and native code (kept from Phase 1). The proposal says only sequences are printed.
- **Very deep recursion** has no depth check. The interpreter uses much more stack per call than native code: a gene that recursed 18,000 levels deep crashed the interpreter (segmentation fault, exit status 139) while the compiled program ran correctly. Native programs can also run out of stack, only at a far greater depth.
- genec -c **needs Clang installed** and runtime/gs_runtime.c next to genec (or the GS_RUNTIME environment variable). Executables are produced for Linux only.
- **Default** genec **mode.** ./genec file.gene runs the interpreter and -c compiles. The proposal's screenshots show compiling with ./genec sample.gene && ./sample; with this implementation the equivalent is ./genec -c sample.gene && ./sample.
- **Integers** cannot be declared, stored, compared, passed, returned or printed, by design of the language (see section 1).